

KEY MOMENT

THE TRENT AFFAIR

On November 8, 1861, Union Captain Charles Wilkes, commanding USS *San Jacinto*, boarded the British steamer, *Trent*, traveling from Havana to England, and arrested Confederate envoys James Murray Mason and John Slidell. Many overly enthusiastic Anglophobic Americans declared Captain Wilkes a hero, while the British were outraged by the breach of neutral rights and the insult given to the British flag. The British government even dispatched 8,000 troops to Canada, though in reality the British armed forces were poorly prepared for war.

In the end, cooler heads prevailed on both sides of the Atlantic, and the Union government released the envoys, while avoiding any acknowledgment of guilt.

